

Morale Booster



DELHI Kamallesh Sharma, India's envoy to the United Kingdom who has won the elections as secretary-general of the Commonwealth will be the first Indian to head the multi-lateral organisation that comprises former British colonies. Sixty-six-year old Sharma is a 1965 batch officer from the

Indian Foreign Service and was elected at the Commonwealth Heads Of Government summit in Uganda, on November 24.

At the retreat, Sharma won with the support of 39 member states out of the 53-member Commonwealth. His nearest rival, Malta's Foreign Minister Michael Frendo, could

only garner the support of 13 countries. According to the Commonwealth rules, since the election of the secretary-general takes place after a consensus through a straw poll, an agreement on Sharma's name was arrived at as India managed to get a backing of all the Commonwealth majors

WINNER: Sharma including the UK, Canada and Australia, besides the entire African block. The spoiler candidate, Mohan Kaul, an NRI businessman, failed to dent Sharma's chances.

The election was a test of sorts for India's diplomatic reflexes as morale in the Ministry of External Affairs had been low ever since the defeat of Shashi Tharoor in the race for UN secretary-general elections last year. Sharma has also had a distinguished career record as the first special representative of UN secretary-general to East Timor.

The Commonwealth has been crusading for democracy and has recently suspended Pakistan for imposing emergency. For Sharma, the real challenge will be to reinvent the Commonwealth and make it relevant in the new global order.

by Saurabh Shukla

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Rahul Gandhi is expected to campaign in the second phase of Gujarat elections, hoping not so much to defeat Narendra Modi as to better his own record of Uttar Pradesh where his presence barely helped the party's vote kitty.

VOICES



"Narendra Modi is a destructive man. Talks about him being a man of development are rubbish."

Uma Bharati, Bharatiya Janshakti Party chief

"If China selected my successor after my death, the people of Tibet would not support him as there would be no Tibetan heart in him."

Dalai Lama, Tibetan spiritual leader

"People think that as a Union minister I can implement schemes with a single signature. But I can do only one per cent of the work. For the rest, I have to struggle."

Anbumani Ramadoss, Union health minister

"Your game is a reflection of your attitude. I'd like to try and instill a psyche where we can go out and fight in each game without thinking about factors beyond our control."

Anil Kumble, Test cricket captain

"Shedding clothes is the easiest thing in the world. But Meena Kumari and Madhubala could kill men by simply raising an eyebrow."

Soha Ali Khan, actor

